year, the party instituted new age-limit rules for its local office-bearers in the states.[80] In UP, for example, the BJP stipulated that no mandal president would be over fifty years of age, no district president above sixty. In a country with one of the youngest populations in the world, this was a political investment in a new generation of leaders. As the BJP's district vice president in Mathura told me, 'The party felt that we need such leaders that can work for us for the next fifteen years. We have now got totally new people. We are developing these people so that this generation can lead us after ten years and so that our generation can do the mentoring after that.'[81] This illustrates a fundamental difference between the two parties: a focus on cadre-building and workers. Much of the public debate on the Congress, meanwhile, remains focused on Rahul Gandhi and his leadership style.

Figure 18.3: A Tale of Forfeited Deposits: The BJP Reduced Such Seats Significantly, While the Congress Forfeitures Zoomed to Almost One-Third of All Lok Sabha Seats (2009–2019)